

Fun in the Sun: The Truth about Sun Tanning

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What better way to prove you've had a great weekend than coming in on Monday with a golden brown tan. You can answer the standard "Do anything fun this weekend?" question without uttering a single word. You radiate evidence of your fun outdoor enjoyment. But being out in the sun carries its own set of dangers: sun burns, painful blisters and peeling, and even skin cancer.

Uncovering the truth about sun tanning requires some explanation of sunlight and how it interacts with our skin.

Ultra-Violet Radiation

The sun is a massive fusion reactor. It pumps out unfathomable amounts of energy. Light and heat are essentially a byproduct of that fusion reaction. That sunlight makes life possible. The light's heat keeps our oceans liquid. The light provides the necessary energy for plant life to grow and keeps mammals warm enough to graze on the surface of our planet. It also makes beach days such a pleasurable activity for us humans.

Within that light, there are a number of frequencies of ultraviolet (UV) radiation, three to be exact: UVA, UVB, and UVC. Two bands affect us directly. One band is significantly more dangerous right now than the others.

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UVC

UVC rays contain the most energy, but the Earth's atmosphere protects us from the damage those rays may cause. This is why environmentalists are so concerned with protecting our ozone layer. Without it, humanity wouldn't just be toast... we'd be really burnt toast.

UVA

UVA, also known as long-wave ultraviolet radiation is able to slip through the atmosphere and hit the surface of our planet at 95% intensity. Our ozone layer is only able to stop 5% of UVA radiation. This band of light is responsible for those golden tans many seek as evidence as a fun-in-the-sun weekend. This wavelength of ultraviolet radiation is also responsible for premature aging and wrinkles (<http://bit.ly/1dXVqh1>).

On the light spectrum, UVA's light wavelength sub-spectrum is right above visible light. This means that if you were to visualize a rainbow, UVA would come right after violet light, hence the term ultraviolet.

Since this wavelength is longer than the other ultraviolet bands of light radiation, it is able to penetrate our skin deeper than UVB. This explains the golden brown tan our bodies create in response to contact with this form of radiation. It is a natural biological response to receiving this form of radiation.

UVB

The midrange wavelength in the ultraviolet spectrum doesn't penetrate human skin as deep as UVA but is capable of damaging the body significantly more. UVB radiation is able to cause damage directly to DNA within the dermis layer of human skin. The World Health Organization is quick to remind (<http://bit.ly/1RwikLM>) outdoor lovers that both UVA and UVB can "cause skin and eye cancer in humans and animals."

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There is a clear indicator that baking yourself in direct sun or in a sun tanning bed can directly lead to various forms of cancer. UV radiation has a cumulative effect but is influenced by an elastic exposure effect. If you get sun a little each day, then the occasional “overdose” of sunlight might affect you less than if you stay shut in for months then have one big outing where you stay in direct sunlight for hours.



How to protect yourself

Clearly, the most important point to remember is to enjoy the sun in moderation. It's not the best plan to just avoid sunlight. In fact, avoidance of sunlight may hurt you more, both with depleted vitamin D production and the possibility of a day where you are stuck out in direct sunlight without protection, which can cause an increased amount of damage.

Enjoy the sun, but be sure to cover up, wear a hat, and apply sunscreen.

When it comes to sunscreen, it's not necessary to go for crazy high SPF numbers. SPF 15 absorbs 93% (<http://bit.ly/1dXVqh1>) of UV radiation, so the key takeaway here is to remember to reapply when out for extended periods of time. Applying SPF 100 may make you feel impervious to the damaging effects of the sun's rays. But after an hour of running around and sweating, you'll likely be just as vulnerable as if you had used SPF 15.

Takeaway

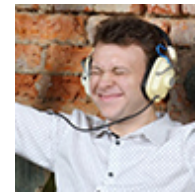
As the days grow longer and the temperatures rise across the nation, and you start planning your fun in the sun, remember to protect yourself. Simple SPF 15, applied regularly, can protect you from painful sunburns or worse. Enjoy your summer, protect yourself and your family, and get out and play!

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